

Prompting Techniques

1 Zero-Shot Prompting

Asking the model to do a task with no examples given.

Example:

“Calculate the area of a rectangle with length 12 cm and width 5 cm.”

2 Few-Shot Prompting

Giving a few examples before the actual task so the model can learn the pattern.

Example:

English: Good morning → French: Bonjour

English: Thank you → French: Merci

English: See you soon → French: ?

3 Chain-of-Thought (CoT) Prompting

Asking the model to reason step-by-step before giving the final answer.

Example:

“A student has 25 chocolates and gives 8 to a friend. Then the student receives 10 more chocolates. How many chocolates does the student have? Think step by step.”

4 Zero-Shot Chain-of-Thought

Just adding “think step by step” without giving examples.

Example:

“A shirt costs 800 and has a 25% discount. What is the final price? Let’s think step by step.”

5 Role-Based (Persona) Prompting

Assigning a role or identity to the model to shape its tone/expertise.

Example:

“You are an experienced Python teacher. Explain what a dictionary is in Python to a beginner.”

6 Instruction-Based Prompting

Giving clear, direct instructions about the desired output format or behavior.

Example:

“Explain the advantages of artificial intelligence in exactly 5 bullet points.”

7 Contextual Prompting

Providing background/context before asking the question.

Example:

“I’m a beginner in programming. Explain what a Python function is using simple language and an easy example.”

8 Self-Consistency Prompting

Asking the model to generate multiple reasoning paths and pick the most consistent answer (usually done programmatically, not just in one prompt).

Example:

“Solve this math problem using 5 different approaches and choose the answer that appears most frequently.”

9 Prompt Chaining

Breaking a complex task into multiple prompts, where the output of one feeds into the next.

Example:

Prompt 1: “Extract the important points from this article.”

Prompt 2: “Using those points, create a short summary.”

Prompt 3: “Convert the summary into 5 bullet points.”

10 Tree-of-Thought Prompting

The model explores multiple possible reasoning branches before settling on an answer (more advanced/structured than CoT).

Example:

“Consider three different ways to solve this problem. Compare each method and select the most effective one.”

11 Retrieval-Augmented Prompting (RAG-style)

Providing external documents/data as context, then asking questions based on that content.

Example:

“Here is a document about a company’s leave policy: [text]. Based on this document, how many paid leaves are available to employees?”

12 Negative Prompting

Telling the model what NOT to do or include.

Example:

“Write a short explanation of machine learning, but do not use technical terms or complicated language.”